

Chapter 68 Part 3

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Liang Shi had brought Xu Qingya to the Xu family home once before, so this time she knew the way well.

After they arrived, they didn't go into the house yet, but went to the cemetery together first.

The cemetery was in the suburbs, in the same direction as coming from Qianshui Bay to the Xu family home. It was about half an hour's drive.

The climate in the suburbs was different from the city—the humidity was higher, and fine, dense rain threads were drifting down.

Liang Shi followed the Xu family's car the whole way. After arriving, she got out first to open her umbrella, then went to the passenger side to receive Xu Qingzhu.

As a result, she saw Xu Qingzhu pull out a folding umbrella from her backpack, revealing just an edge of it.

She moved her umbrella farther away, but then Xu Qingzhu directly placed her backpack in the back seat without taking anything out, and got out of the car on her own.

Liang Shi immediately held the umbrella over her.

Xu Qingya was holding a small blue umbrella by herself, standing in the rain looking at the two of them. "You two only brought one umbrella?"

Xu Qingzhu replied without changing her expression, "Mm."

Liang Shi: "?"

She began to suspect she had seen wrong.

However, this was just a small episode.

After entering the cemetery, they still had to walk quite a distance. Xu Guangyao and Sheng Linlang also shared one umbrella. Xu Guangyao's tall and large frame made Sheng Linlang appear even more frail.

For some reason, looking at them from behind, Liang Shi inexplicably felt that Sheng Linlang's back looked desolate.

In this world, the people with direct blood relations to her seemed to be only her two daughters left.

Her parents had fallen ill from worry over their only younger brother and passed away early.

Only she was left to support the enormous Sheng family.

Actually, thinking about it carefully, one could understand. Over these many years, although Xu Guangyao wasn't talented at business, he had indeed been good to Sheng Linlang and their two daughters. He might have some inherent character flaws, such as arrogance and stubbornness that couldn't be changed, but he was a qualified father who did everything for his daughters' sake.

Back when Sheng Linlang had shouldered such a huge burden, it had always been Xu Guangyao by her side accompanying her.

Liang Shi suddenly felt that Sheng Linlang was a very intelligent woman.

When Sheng Linlang was young, she was beautiful. Calling her Haizhou City's number one beauty would not be an exaggeration. Many talented young men and beautiful women came to pursue her, but she chose Xu Guangyao.

Because she knew that people couldn't remain beautiful forever, and those who came for the Sheng family and her beauty might very well have affairs after she grew old and lost her looks, or swallow up the Sheng family, especially those whose own family businesses were also doing well.

No one could refuse the piece of cake that was the Sheng family.

Perhaps many people had ridiculed Sheng Linlang for being foolish back then, but for Sheng Linlang, she had made a decision that wasn't wrong.

At least both daughters were raised very well.

The cemetery was very large. Buried here were the Sheng family parents, and also Sheng Qinglin.

Sheng Linlang placed the flowers she brought in front of Sheng Qinglin's grave. The fine rain threads made everything seem desolate yet peaceful.

After a long while, Sheng Linlang called Liang Shi and Xu Qingzhu over. Like a family matriarch, she introduced them to Sheng Qinglin in a low voice. "Qinglin, this is Liang Shi, Qingzhu's wife. She's pretty, right? Just as pretty as our Qingzhu."

"She's also a very good person, and Qingzhu likes her very much. They didn't come to see you when they got married before, but now you've met her, so it can be considered fulfilling a wish." After introducing Liang Shi, Sheng Linlang called Xu Qingya over and nagged a few words about her grades, even saying Xu Qingya wasn't like her uncle at all—not clever.

Xu Qingya pouted but didn't argue back.

Although her grades were first in the entire grade.

But everyone in the Xu family knew that there were three days in the year when you absolutely couldn't provoke Sheng Linlang—the death anniversaries of the Sheng family parents and Sheng Qinglin's death anniversary.

Otherwise, their mother would seem like a different person, either crying endlessly or losing her temper.

Over so many years, this had become an unspoken "rule" of the Sheng family.

After paying respects to Sheng Qinglin, they stood for a while in front of the Sheng family parents' graves.

Liang Shi stood there observing a moment of silence for a few minutes. When she raised her head, her gaze casually swept around, and she discovered a black figure.

Just a back view, but it gave Liang Shi an unusually familiar feeling.

The person was wearing a black qipao¹, walking step by step toward the cemetery exit, swaying gracefully.

Liang Shi immediately tugged at Xu Qingzhu, gesturing for her to look in that direction. Xu Qingzhu's eyes immediately widened, and she mouthed to her: "Yang Jiani?"

Liang Shi nodded.

They watched Yang Jiani's figure disappear into the cemetery.

The conclusions they'd deduced last night seemed to be right before their eyes, ready to be verified.

When Xu Guangyao and the others were preparing to leave, Xu Qingzhu suddenly asked, "Mom and Dad, do you know President Qi from Qida Company? That person who's famously devoted to his family."

Xu Guangyao frowned upon hearing this. "What's wrong?"

"Just asking casually." Xu Qingzhu didn't mention Liang Shi's affairs, and casually made up an excuse. "I met his wife recently, and I feel that President Qi isn't as simple as he appears on the surface."

"Is it Jiani?" Sheng Linlang suddenly asked.

Xu Qingzhu nodded. "Right, right, right. His wife is called Yang Jiani. Mom, do you know her?"

In the bleak rain, a gust of autumn wind swept past, making people shiver from the cold.

The rain was getting heavier. Liang Shi tilted the umbrella more toward Xu Qingzhu's side, leaving half of her own shoulder exposed outside, but Xu Qingzhu imperceptibly leaned closer to her, then placed her hand on Liang Shi's wrist, straightening the umbrella's direction.

Sheng Linlang slowly nodded. "We were very close when we were young."

"What kind of person is she?" Xu Qingzhu asked, "Are you still in contact now?"

Sheng Linlang shook her head. "After her family went bankrupt, she stopped contacting us."

Xu Qingzhu frowned. "Haven't you seen her since then?"

Sheng Linlang glanced at the cemetery. "Every Qingming Festival², I put a bouquet of flowers in front of her parents' grave. Her parents are also buried in this cemetery."

"When is their death anniversary?" Xu Qingzhu asked.

Sheng Linlang said, "March."

Xu Qingzhu asked which area Yang Jiani's parents' graves were in, then planned to go look with Liang Shi in a bit.

After a while, Sheng Linlang suddenly said, "One year she called me in the middle of the night, saying she'd gone crazy, and also saying her daughter had died."

Sheng Linlang shook her head on her own. "But she hung up after just a few words. When I called her back, she didn't answer. Later when she did answer, she told me not to contact her anymore, so we haven't been in contact since."

"When was that?" Xu Qingzhu continued asking.

Sheng Linlang thought carefully. "Around when you were nine, I think. Back then you were getting sick every few days, and I couldn't spare attention for her. When she called me, you were still running a fever..."

Xu Qingzhu fell silent. "I see."

Footnotes

¹ *Qipao* - Also known as cheongsam, a traditional Chinese dress characterized by a high collar, fitted bodice, and side slits. It's a form-fitting one-piece dress that became popular in the 1920s and remains an iconic garment in Chinese culture.

² *Qingming Festival* - Also known as Tomb-Sweeping Day, this is a traditional Chinese festival usually occurring around April 4-6, when families visit the graves of their ancestors to clean the tombstones, pray, and make ritual offerings.